

nff-power-meter

Shunt-based energy measurement of ESP32 firmware operations

Experiment datasheet — Revision A

Bench rig: STM32 Nucleo-F446RE + ESP32 DevKit

2026-07-13

Abstract

This document specifies the bench rig used to measure the electrical energy consumed by an ESP32 device while it executes an **nff** operation — principally **nff ota**, the only **nff** command that places a sustained load (WiFi RX + flash writes) on the target. The measurand is **joules per OTA**. A $1\,\Omega$ shunt in the ESP32's ground return is sampled at 200 kSps by an STM32 Nucleo-F446RE, which accumulates charge and energy *in firmware* and reports running totals on demand. The host never integrates, and therefore cannot silently drop samples and under-report energy.

Three guards decide whether a run is reportable at all, and each exists because the rig produced a confident, plausible, *wrong* number during bring-up (§10): a DMA-overflow counter (dropped conversions), a window cross-check (a lost **ZERO** once turned a 30 s run into 91 s and 26 J), and an active continuity probe (a rig wired to *nothing* reported 590 mA and a 4.94 V rail). If any fails, no joules figure is reported.

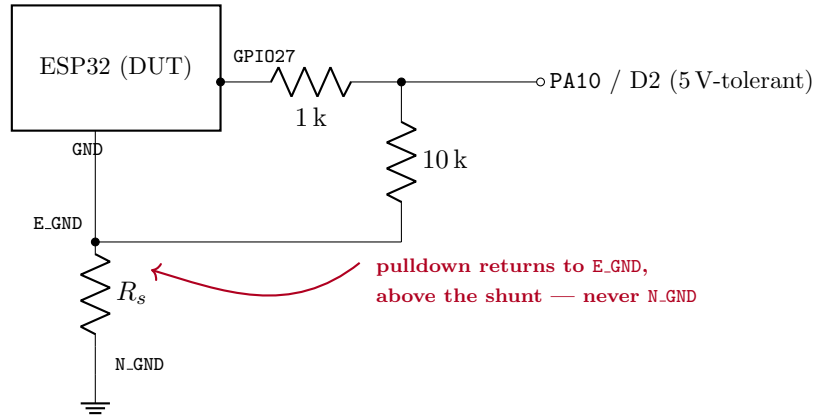
Contents

1	Scope and measurand	3
2	Measurement principle	3
3	Schematic	3
3.1	Power path	3
3.2	Phase marker (Phase 5, optional)	4
4	Bill of materials	4
5	Connection table	5
6	Electrical design budget	5
6.1	Shunt sizing and LDO headroom	5
6.2	ADC scaling, sampling budget, and why the divider is 1 k Ω	5
6.3	Sampling budget	6
6.4	V_{DDA} tolerance	6
7	Firmware integration mathematics	6
7.1	Baseline subtraction	7
8	Calibration procedure (Phase 0)	7
9	Host interface	8
10	How the rig refuses to lie	8
10.1	ovr — dropped conversions	8
10.2	Window cross-check — a lost ZERO	8
10.3	WIRECHECK — a rig wired to nothing	9
11	Capability envelope	9
12	Error budget	10
13	Operating rules	10
14	Verification sequence	10
15	Measurement log	11

The return-path trap. The bulk capacitor C_b returns to **E_GND** — the DUT’s *own* ground, at the top of the shunt — **not** to **N_GND**. A component returned to **N_GND** carries DUT current that bypasses the shunt entirely and is therefore invisible to the meter: a silent, systematic under-read. The same rule governs the marker pulldown below. Note C_f (on PA1) is exempt: it carries no DUT current, only ADC sample-and-hold charge, so it returns to **N_GND**.

3.2 Phase marker (Phase 5, optional)

Drawn separately because its ground return is the easiest thing on this rig to get wrong.



Every ESP32 GPIO goes high-impedance during reset, and an OTA *ends* in a reboot — so without the pulldown the marker line floats through precisely the phase transition being captured. The 10 kΩ holds it at a defined low; the 1 kΩ protects both pins should one end be misconfigured as an output. Returning the pulldown to **N_GND** would route $\approx 330 \mu\text{A}$ of DUT current around the shunt.

Two markers are better than one. A single pin distinguishes only “in a phase / not in a phase”. Two pins (e.g. GPIO27 + GPIO26 into two FT inputs) give a 2-bit code — exactly the four OTA phases worth separating: download / write / verify / reboot. Same wiring cost.

4 Bill of materials

Ref	Value	Notes
MCU	Nucleo-F446RE	Meter + host link. Only device connected to the PC.
DUT	ESP32 devkit (WROOM-32)	Powered exclusively from the Nucleo 5 V pin.
R_s	1 Ω, 0.25 W	Shunt. Ten 10 Ω in parallel is an acceptable substitute (also averages tolerance down).
R_1, R_2	1 to 10 kΩ	Rail divider, matched pair; 1 % preferred (ratio error is a direct gain error on energy). 10 kΩ/10 kΩ settles with $\approx 6\times$ margin — see §6.2. Ratio is 2.0 either way.
C_b	100 μF	<i>Optional.</i> Bulk decoupling, VIN→E_GND only .
C_f	100 nF	<i>Optional.</i> PA1 to N_GND ; buffers the ADC sample-and-hold. Not required at 10 kΩ, but harmless insurance.
R_3	1 kΩ	Marker series protection (Phase 5).
R_4	10 kΩ	Marker pulldown to E_GND (Phase 5).
<i>Reference instrument:</i> bench multimeter, used for calibration only.		

5 Connection table

Nucleo	Arduino hdr	Connects to	Function
5V	CN6-5	ESP32 VIN (= 5V)	Supply rail
GND	CN6-6	Bottom of R_s / divider bottom	System ground, ADC reference
PA0	A0	Top of $R_s = E_GND$	Shunt sense, 200 kSps
PA1	A1	Divider midpoint	Rail sense, $V_{\text{rail}}/2$
PA10	D2	ESP32 GPIO27 via 1 k Ω	Phase marker (optional, 5 V-tolerant)
ESP32 USB port: not connected. See §13.			

Why PA10 and not PA4. PA4 is a DAC pin and is *not* 5 V-tolerant. The marker’s logic high arrives at up to 3.6 V (3.3 V referenced to a ground that is itself floating 0.3 V up), leaving PA4 no headroom. PA10 is an FT pin.

Why GPIO27 on the DUT. Not a strapping pin, not a flash pin (GPIO6–11), not input-only (GPIO34/35/36/39), no default peripheral, no boot-time glitch. GPIO13/25/26/33 are equivalent alternates. **Never GPIO12** — it is the MTDI strapping pin; held high at reset it selects a 1.8 V flash supply and the board will not boot.

6 Electrical design budget

6.1 Shunt sizing and LDO headroom

At the WiFi TX peak, $I_{\text{pk}} \approx 300 \text{ mA}$:

$$V_{R_s} = I_{\text{pk}} R_s = 0.3 \text{ V}, \quad P_{R_s} = I_{\text{pk}}^2 R_s = 90 \text{ mW} \quad (< 250 \text{ mW rating}).$$

The Nucleo’s 5 V pin, when the board is USB-powered, sits near 4.7 V (ST-Link protection diode drop). The DUT’s AMS1117 therefore sees

$$V_{\text{LDO,in}} = 4.7 \text{ V} - 0.3 \text{ V} = 4.4 \text{ V},$$

which is at — not above — the AMS1117’s worst-case dropout floor for a 3.3 V output.

Do not increase R_s beyond 1 Ω without addressing headroom. At 2 Ω the peak drop is 0.6 V and the LDO browns out mid-OTA. If the DUT resets or resets intermittently during WiFi TX, the remedies in order of preference are: (i) drop to 0.5 Ω (two 1 Ω in parallel), accepting half the sensitivity; (ii) fit C_b across VIN–E_GND; (iii) power the Nucleo from an external 7 to 12 V supply on its own VIN, which yields a solid 5.0 V rail.

6.2 ADC scaling, sampling budget, and why the divider is 1 k Ω

Both channels are read by the F446’s 12 bit SAR ADC against $V_{\text{DDA}} \approx 3.3 \text{ V}$.

	PA0 (shunt)	PA1 (rail)
Input range at ADC	0 to 0.5 V (typ.)	$\approx 2.35 \text{ V}$
Corresponding quantity	0 to 500 mA	$\approx 4.7 \text{ V rail}$
Full-scale before clipping	3.3 A	6.6 V rail
Raw LSB	0.806 mV $\rightarrow$ 0.81 mA	1.6 mV rail
After 256 $\times$ decimation	$\approx 0.05 \text{ mA}$	—
Source impedance	$\approx R_s$, negligible	5 k Ω (Thévenin, 10k 10k)
Sampling time	15 cyc.	56 cyc.

Averaging $N = 256$ samples recovers $\log_4 N = 4$ effective bits, giving an effective 16 bit resolution — roughly 0.05 mA per count. This is what makes a bare 12 bit ADC with no front-end usable.

Divider impedance: 10 k Ω /10 k Ω is fine

The ADC input is an RC: the sample-and-hold capacitor ($C_{\text{ADC}} \approx 4 \text{ pF}$) charges through the source impedance plus the internal mux resistance ($R_{\text{ADC}} \approx 6 \text{ k}\Omega$). Settling to $\frac{1}{2}$ LSB at 12 bit needs $\approx \ln(2^{13}) \approx 9\tau$. For a 10 k Ω /10 k Ω divider (a 5 k Ω Thévenin source):

$$\tau = (5 \text{ k}\Omega + 6 \text{ k}\Omega) \cdot 4 \text{ pF} \approx 44 \text{ ns}, \quad t_{\text{settle}} \approx 9\tau \approx 0.4 \mu\text{s} \ll \underbrace{\frac{56}{22.5 \text{ MHz}}}_{\text{available at 56 cyc.}} = 2.49 \mu\text{s}$$

— roughly **6 $\times$ margin**. The 480-cycle figure sometimes quoted is the spec for a $\approx 200 \text{ k}\Omega$ source, which a resistor divider is nowhere near.

1 k Ω /1 k Ω works equally well and has more margin still, at the cost of $\approx 2.5 \text{ mA}$ drawn from a rail that is already tight for the DUT's peaks (§6.1). That current returns to N_GND *without passing through the shunt*, so it does not corrupt the measurement either way. **Use whichever you have.** The ratio is 2.0 in both cases, so KDIV is unchanged.

Acceptance check, not an argument. A source impedance too high for its sampling window biases the rail reading *low*, silently — and every joule scales with the rail. So verify it: compare the rail PA1 reports (**nff power monitor**) against the multimeter. They must agree. If PA1 reads low, drop to 1 k Ω /1 k Ω or fit C_f .

6.3 Sampling budget

The ADC clock is PCLK2/4 = 22.5 MHz, and a 12 bit conversion costs $(t_{\text{samp}} + 12)$ ADC cycles. One scan of both ranks is therefore

$$\underbrace{(15 + 12)}_{\text{PA0}} + \underbrace{(56 + 12)}_{\text{PA1}} = 95 \text{ cycles} = 4.22 \mu\text{s},$$

against the 5.00 μs that the 200 kSps trigger allows — about 16% headroom. If that budget is ever violated the ovr counter says so; it is not left to inference. *Measured on the bench:* 2040576 samples in 10 s ($f_s = 199\,998 \text{ Hz}$), ovr = 0.

6.4 V_{DDA} tolerance

The Nucleo's 3.3 V regulator has a $\pm 2\%$ tolerance, which appears as a $\pm 2\%$ gain error on *both* channels.

This is absorbed by the R_{eff} calibration (§8), not corrected independently. Calibration solves R_{eff} from a measured current, so any gain error common to the chain — resistor tolerance, ADC gain, V_{DDA} — lands in that single constant. They are not separable, and they do not need to be.

Not implemented: the F446 carries a factory VREFINT constant at 0x1FFF7A2A from which the true V_{DDA} could be derived independently ($V_{\text{DDA}} = 3.3 \text{ V} \cdot \text{VREFINT_CAL}/\text{VREFINT_DATA}$). The firmware does *not* read it, because calibration already absorbs the error. It would only earn its keep if one wanted an *uncalibrated* absolute reading, or to track V_{DDA} drift with temperature.

7 Firmware integration mathematics

Let k index samples taken at $\Delta t = 5 \mu\text{s}$ ($f_s = 200 \text{ kSps}$), and let q_k, u_k be the *raw ADC counts* on PA0 and PA1. With $L = V_{\text{DDA}}/4096$ the volts-per-count, K the divider ratio (2.0 for a matched pair) and R_{eff} the *calibrated* shunt resistance (§8) — not the nominal 1 Ω :

$$I_k = \frac{q_k L}{R_{\text{eff}}}, \quad V_{\text{board},k} = \underbrace{K u_k L}_{\text{rail}} - \underbrace{q_k L}_{\text{ground lift}}.$$

Energy then collapses into sums the firmware can keep in *exact integers*:

$$E = \sum_k V_{\text{board},k} I_k \Delta t = \frac{L^2}{R_{\text{eff}}} \cdot \frac{1}{f_s} \left(K \sum_k u_k q_k - \sum_k q_k^2 \right), \quad Q = \frac{L}{R_{\text{eff}}} \cdot \frac{1}{f_s} \sum_k q_k.$$

So the STM32 accumulates only $\sum q$, $\sum q^2$, $\sum uq$, $\sum u$ and n — as `uint64`, which a 10 min run at 200 kSps does not come close to overflowing — and the host multiplies by constants. A float accumulator would drift over 10^7 samples; these do not.

The host never integrates. This is deliberate: a host-side integrator that misses serial frames silently under-reports energy, and the loss is invisible in the output. Here a missed frame costs nothing — the next frame carries the correct cumulative total — and a missed *conversion* cannot hide either, because it sets `ovr` (§10).

7.1 Baseline subtraction

A command’s cost is defined as the energy *above* the cost of merely being powered on:

$$P_{\text{idle}} = \frac{E(t_1) - E(t_0)}{t_1 - t_0} \Big|_{\text{DUT idle, WiFi connected}}, \quad \boxed{E_{\text{marg}} = E_{\text{total}} - P_{\text{idle}} \cdot T_{\text{cmd}}}$$

E_{marg} is the reported headline figure. Because the LDO loss, USB–UART bridge and power LED are present in both terms, they cancel.

8 Calibration procedure (Phase 0)

Do not skip, and repeat after *any* rewiring. Breadboard contact resistance is 10 to 100 m Ω *per contact* and sits in series with a 1 Ω shunt. It is not negligible, and it changes when a wire is re-seated.

1. Wire the rig per the schematic. Flash the meter firmware.
2. Hang a known resistive load on the DUT’s 3.3 V rail — 100 Ω gives ≈ 33 mA.
3. Read the true current I_{DMM} with the multimeter *in series* with that load.
4. Read the current I_{rep} the STM32 reports, assuming nominal $R_s = 1 \Omega$.
5. Solve for the effective shunt and persist it:

$$R_{\text{eff}} = R_{\text{nom}} \cdot \frac{I_{\text{rep}}}{I_{\text{DMM}}}$$

This single constant absorbs the resistor’s tolerance, the ADC gain error, *and* the breadboard contact resistance.

6. Repeat for the divider: measure the rail with the DMM, compare against $2 V_{\text{PA1}}$, and store the ratio correction.

Acceptance criterion. After calibration, the STM32 and the multimeter must agree to within a few percent on a purely resistive load. *If they do not, stop* — nothing built on top of this rig is worth anything.

9 Host interface

ST-Link Virtual COM Port, 921 600 baud, 8N1, line-oriented ASCII.

Dir	Command	Meaning
H→M	PING	Liveness / identification probe.
H→M	INFO	Firmware identity, f_s , calibration constants.
H→M	ZERO	Reset the accumulators and the clock. Acknowledged.
H→M	SNAP	Emit one frame <i>now</i> .
H→M	STREAM <0 1>	Free-run frames at 10 Hz (live monitor view only).
H→M	WIRECHECK	Actively probe whether PA0/PA1 are connected (§10).
H→M	CAL <micro_ohm>	Set R_{eff} .
H→M	KDIV <milli>	Set the divider ratio $\times 1000$ (2000 = any matched pair).
H→M	VDDA <mv>	Set the assumed ADC reference.
M→H	(frame)	One JSON object per line.

Calibration lives on the host (`~/.nff/config.json`) and is pushed down with CAL/KDIV/VDDA on every connect. The meter is stateless across resets; there is one source of truth.

Frames are emitted on demand, not free-running. A meter that chatters continuously leaves the host unable to say exactly when accumulation stopped relative to the profiled command exiting — it would over-attribute up to a frame’s worth of idle energy to it. `measure` therefore drives ZERO → run → SNAP.

```
{
  "t":10200,"n":2040576,"ovr":0,"sq":141600000,"sqq":9832000000,
  "suq":4.39e11,"su":6.33e9,"qmax":410,"fs":200000,"vdda":3300,
  "r":1000000,"kdiv":2000}
```

The frame carries *raw integer sums*, not derived joules. Two reasons. It keeps the accumulation exact — a float accumulator drifts over 10^7 samples — and it means a *re*-calibration can re-derive the energy of a past run without re-measuring it.

10 How the rig refuses to lie

Every guard here exists because the rig produced a confident, plausible, *wrong* number during bring-up. None is hypothetical, and `ovr` alone catches none of the last two.

10.1 ovr — dropped conversions

A missed conversion means the accumulators are an under-count. If `ovr` > 0, or the profiled child process exits non-zero, the host reports `ok: false` and does **not** present a joules figure. A plausible-but-wrong energy number is worse than no number, because it will be trusted.

10.2 Window cross-check — a lost ZERO

A ZERO that never lands leaves the meter accumulating *from boot*, so the frame describes the board’s uptime rather than the command.

Observed: a 30 s run reported 91 s and 26 J — with `ovr` = 0, a perfectly sane 58 mA, and `ok: true`. The overrun counter cannot catch this: no samples were lost. The *window* was wrong.

ZERO is now acknowledged, and the host cross-checks (a) the meter’s own elapsed clock against how long it actually waited, and (b) that the samples delivered match the claimed f_s — if the ADC is not running at f_s , every Δt , and so every joule, is scaled wrong.

10.3 WIRECHECK — a rig wired to nothing

The nastiest failure, and it defeated two designs before this one.

An unconnected ADC pin does not read zero — it holds charge. With *nothing attached at all*, the meter reported 590 mA and a rail of 4.94 V. Both are entirely plausible. Any passive range check waves them straight through.

An internal pull-up/pull-down probe fails too: it reported both pins “connected” with nothing attached, because **the F446’s ADC cannot read a pad while the GPIO is in digital-input mode** (the analog switch is open), and the pulls are *disabled* in analog mode — so there is no configuration in which both work.

What survives is to **drive the node, release it to analog, and read it immediately**. A real source restores its own voltage in nanoseconds (the divider is a few-k Ω source; the shunt node is a near short to ground). A floating node keeps the charge. Measured: a floating PA0 stayed 1 746 counts off, a floating PA1 2 425 counts off; a wired node moves under 100.

For the divider, both tests must pass: it must *read* like a 5 V rail *and* spring back. Either alone can be passed by luck — the bench’s floating PA1 sat at a convincing 4.94 V — but it restored to 0.5 V, and nothing genuinely connected does that.

PA0 is only ever driven LOW. Driving it high would put the GPIO against the 1 Ω shunt straight to ground — ≈ 65 mA, well past the pin’s 25 mA rating. PA1 is safe to drive both ways: the divider’s series resistance limits the current to a few mA.

11 Capability envelope

	Quantity	Remark
yes	Active-mode current, joules per OTA	The target measurand.
yes	Idle / connected-but-quiet baseline	Required for marginal subtraction.
yes	Peak current ($i_{\max}$)	Smoothed if C_b is fitted; Q and E remain exact.
no	Deep sleep	$10\,\mu\text{A} \times 1\,\Omega = 10\,\mu\text{V}$, roughly $100\times$ below the breadboard noise floor. Unrecoverable without a real front-end (INA228, PPK2).
no	nff flash, nff monitor	Require the DUT’s USB, which shorts the shunt.
<i>Caveat:</i> the measurement is whole-board, not ESP32-die. Constant, so it cancels in E_{marg} .		

12 Error budget

Source	Raw	Residual	Treatment
Shunt tolerance ($\pm 5\%$)	5 %	$< 0.5\%$	Absorbed by R_{eff} calibration.
Breadboard contact resistance	1 to 10 %	$< 1\%$	Absorbed by calibration; drifts on re-seat.
V _D DA regulator ($\pm 2\%$)	2 %	$< 0.5\%$	Absorbed by R_{eff} calibration (<i>not</i> VREFINT — see §6.4).
Divider ratio	1 %	$< 0.5\%$	Calibrated against the DMM.
Divider source impedance	—	≈ 0	1 to 10 k Ω both settle with $\approx 6\times$ margin at 56 cycles (§6.2). Verify the rail against the DMM.
Shunt tempco (self-heating, 90 mW)	—	$\approx 1\%$	Uncorrected. Carbon film ≈ 300 ppm/ $^{\circ}\text{C}$.
ADC INL/DNL	—	$\approx 0.2\%$	Uncorrected, small.
Aliasing of WiFi TX spikes	—	sample-rate bound	Mitigated by $f_s = 200$ kSps; C_b trades peak fidelity for stability.
Dropped conversions	—	detected	ovr counter $\rightarrow$ ok: false .
Wrong accumulation window	—	detected	ZERO ack + host/meter clock cross-check.
Rig not actually wired	—	detected	WIRECHECK drive-and-release probe.
Expected overall		≈ 2 to 3%	On active-mode energy, post-calibration.

The rig is designed for *relative* fidelity: a 2 % absolute error is irrelevant to the regression gate, which compares an OTA against a previously measured OTA on the same, un-rewired rig.

13 Operating rules

- R1. The ESP32 must not be plugged into the PC's USB.** A USB cable ties the DUT's ground to PC ground, which shorts the shunt out. A reading of ≈ 0 mA during a known-active phase is the signature of exactly this mistake. It is also the reason `nff flash` and `nff monitor` cannot be profiled here.
- R2. Only the Nucleo connects to the PC.**
- R3. $R_s = 1\ \Omega$, 0.25 W.** Do not exceed 1 Ω without bulk capacitance — the DUT's LDO will brown out (§6.1).
- R4. Recalibrate after any rewiring.** Contact resistance is in the measurement path.
- R5. All DUT return currents pass through the shunt.** C_b and the marker pulldown return to E_GND, never N_GND.

14 Verification sequence

Run in order. Each step gates the next.

1. **Resistive-load check.** 100 Ω on the DUT's 3.3 V rail. `nff power monitor` must agree with the multimeter to within a few percent. *If it does not, nothing else counts.*
2. **Baseline.** `nff power measure --for 30`, DUT idle and WiFi-connected. Expect tens of mA. A reading near zero means the shunt is shorted — check R1.

3. **The real number.** nff power measure --during "nff ota ..." → joules per OTA. Confirm `ovr = 0`.
4. **Regression gate.** Re-run with `--max-joules` set just below the measured value; confirm exit status 1.
5. **Agent loop.** Call the `power_measure` MCP tool; confirm the agent receives a structured verdict.

Reporting. State the measured joules-per-OTA plainly, including whether `ovr` was clean. If the rig cannot be made to agree with the multimeter, say so — do not report a number.

15 Measurement log

Date	R_{eff}	P_{idle}	E_{marg}	i_{max}	ovr	Notes
2026-07-14	1.0 Ω nom.	206 mW	5.37 J	314 mA	0	1 MiB OTA, esp32-nffload. 3.06×10^6 samples. Uncalibrated — resistor measures 1.1 Ω .
2026-07-14	—	—	—	—	0	f_s verified: 2040576 samples in 10 s = 199998 Hz.
2026-07-13	—	—	—	—	—	WIRECHECK bring-up: wired to <i>nothing</i> , the rig read a plausible 590 mA and a 4.94 V rail.

*Revision A.1 — rig **built, debugged and in service** (2026-07-14). It has produced real numbers: see `nff-power-characteristics.tex`. **Phase 0 calibration still not performed**, so absolute figures carry 10 to 30%; relative figures are good to a few percent. The measurement log below is real.*